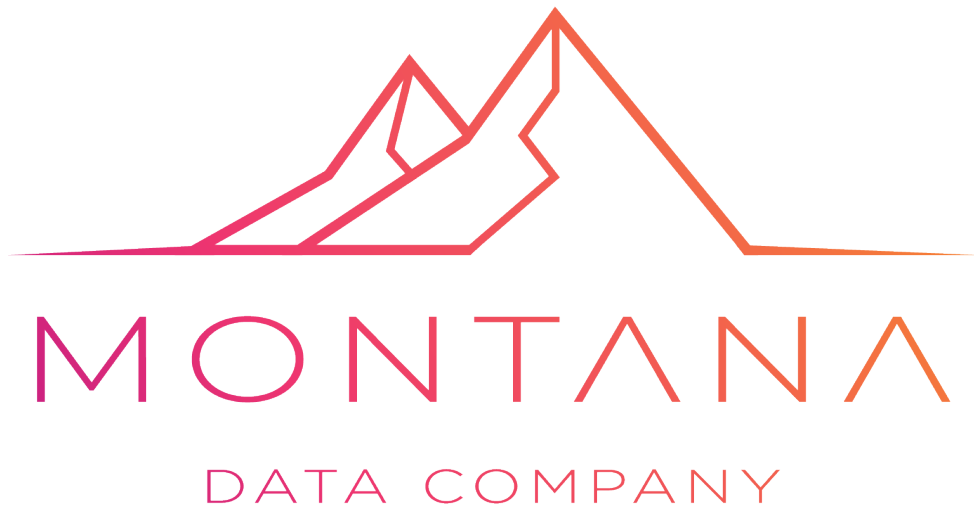




THE INFORMATION OFFICER'S HANDBOOK

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A Practical POPIA Guide for South African Information Officers.

Prepared for: Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs) and Operational Information Officers

Purpose: Practical guidance for complying with the Protection of Personal Information Act (POPIA) in South Africa

1. Introduction

Under South Africa's Protection of Personal Information Act (POPIA), every organisation that processes personal information must ensure that personal information is processed lawfully, securely, and transparently.

The Information Officer (IO) plays a central governance role in ensuring compliance with POPIA and promoting responsible information management practices.

This handbook provides a concise operational reference for Information Officers and Deputy Information Officers.

2. What is an Information Officer?

An Information Officer is the individual legally responsible for ensuring that an organisation complies with:

- The Protection of Personal Information Act (POPIA)
- The Promotion of Access to Information Act (PAIA)

For most private organisations, the default Information Officer is the CEO or equivalent head of the organisation.

Deputy Information Officers may be appointed to assist with operational responsibilities.

3. Core Responsibilities of the Information Officer

The Information Officer is responsible for:

Governance and Compliance

- Establishing POPIA compliance controls
- Developing and maintaining privacy policies
- Monitoring organisational compliance
- Promoting a culture of privacy and data protection

Risk Management

- Identifying privacy and data protection risks
- Ensuring safeguards are implemented
- Monitoring third-party data processing risks

Information Security Oversight

- Ensuring reasonable technical and organisational safeguards exist
- Coordinating incident response processes
- Supporting breach investigations and reporting

Training and Awareness

- Providing employee awareness training
- Ensuring staff understand POPIA obligations
- Promoting secure handling of personal information

Data Subject Rights Management

- Managing access requests
- Handling correction or deletion requests
- Managing objections and complaints

Regulatory Engagement

- Registering Information Officers with the Information Regulator
- Cooperating with the Information Regulator
- Managing notifications where required

4. Key POPIA Concepts Every Information Officer Must Understand

Personal Information

Personal information includes any information relating to an identifiable person or juristic entity.

Examples include:

- Names and surnames
- Identity numbers
- Contact details
- Financial information
- Employment records
- Email addresses
- Location information
- Online identifiers
- Biometric information

Special Personal Information

Certain categories require additional protection, including:

- Health information
- Religious beliefs
- Biometric information
- Trade union membership
- Criminal behaviour records
- Children's information

Processing

Processing includes:

- Collection

- Storage
- Access
- Sharing
- Transmission
- Modification
- Deletion
- Destruction

Contact Us

If you would like to discuss your organisation's specific requirements, risks, compliance obligations, cybersecurity posture, business continuity strategy, or operational resilience objectives in greater detail, we invite you to contact Montana Data Company.

Our team can assist with tailored assessments, strategic guidance, governance support, and practical implementation aligned to your organisation's unique operational and regulatory environment.

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